based childhood', he elaborates, has disrupted the developmental pathways of these children, affecting their ability to take risks, overcome fears, manage challenges and form deep relationships. The trend is seeping into India as well, where vulnerable young adults entering the workforce often lack the resilience required in today's demanding work environments, says Shankar. The breakdown of natural support systems like friends and family is not helping either. "We need social connections—friendship and camaraderie—to be happy," says Dharmaraj, "but people spend 10-12 hours working, another 2-3 hours commuting, leaving no time to unwind or to invest in relationships and personal interests."

WHAT STRESS DOES TO YOUR BODY

Every time a person is stressed, either because of a looming work deadline or the dread of an upcoming meeting, it triggers a primitive human response known as 'flight or fight'. This results in the spike of certain stress hormones, enzymes and suchlike, e.g. cortisol, lipids, triglycerides (fat in blood), histamines, adrenaline, and even lactic acid, explains Dr S.P. Byotra, senior consultant at Sir Ganga Ram Hospital. If the body is constantly in a state of fight-or-flight, it starts overreacting to stressors, leading to an accumulation of stress hormones and enzymes in the bloodstream, he says. In excess, these can become toxic, straining various organs, particularly the heart. So, if a person has been overwhelmed by work for months, working extra hours each week, they may begin to dread Monday mornings, even during lean work periods, or feel exhausted just being at the office. "If the body remains under psychological stress, over time, it can turn into pathological stress," says Dr Byotra. The same adrenaline rush to meet a deadline on time might in due course may turn to exhaustion and fatigue.

The body needs time to down its shutters, rest and recharge. Long working hours deny humans something as basic as 7-8 hours of sleep, a primal necessity. Rohin Basu (*name changed*), an IT professional with 23 years of experience, recalls how, in his first job at a computational technology provider, his manager would make him work through the night, even when he was sick. "An average day was 12 hours, and this went on for two years. Eventually, I had a nervous breakdown," he says.

Stress begins showing up in various ways. A person may become more prone to migraines or headaches, hypertension, heart palpitations, indigestion, muscle or joint pain, skin eruptions, loss of appetite or overeating, sleeplessness and fatigue. They may also become irritable or angry, suffer from extreme anxiety or worry, be depressed or low, have problems concentrating and feel overwhelmed all the time. A 2024 report by Gallup, 'State of the Global Workplace', which surveyed 128,278 employees in 160 countries found that 35 per cent of the 1,000-odd Indian employees they surveyed reported feeling anger and 42 per cent reported feeling sadness 'a lot during the day'. This is significantly higher than the global averages of 21 per cent and 22 per cent, respectively. The emotional and mental stress makes individuals underconfident and prone to low self-esteem, making them less productive, erratic in their work patterns, unmindful of their responsibilities. Some also start withdrawing socially, avoiding colleagues and managers, eating alone, and becoming restless and negative in their overall view of life.

To cope, they often tend to make poor lifestyle choices, such as sleeping less, eating unhealthy food, or barely indulging in any physical activity, points out Dr Rahul Chandhok, psychiatrist and head consultant of mental health and behavioral science at Artemis Hospitals. "In fact, stressed patients often resort to smoking and excessive alcohol consumption, further increasing the risk of other health problems," he says.

HOW TO BEAT WORK STRESS

The best thing companies can do for their employees, says Dr Byotra, is to ensure they get proper sleep, exercise, nutrition and rest every day. "The notion that weekdays are for work and only weekends for rest is flawed. These elements of well-being cannot be compartmentalised," he says. There should be space within

WHAT COMPANIES MUST DO TO EASE WORKPLACE STRESS

Best practices from organisations that prioritise employee mental health, provide a positive work environment and accessible mental health resources

